

The Gathering of the People
First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this afternoon and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert **Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence**

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome **Rev. Ashley Hiestand**

Words of Gathering **Rev. Laura Vail Fregin & Rev. Michael Lehman**
Each time as we gather,
our task in worship is no less than to dream
an impossible future
shaped by glimpses of a realm
of justice and life.

We are called here to boldly imagine
an impossible world
where what is broken is restored to wholeness
where the dead is brought to life.

In this time apart, we bring the world’s most damaged realities
and hold them with faith that they will be changed
in the presence of hope and love.

Can you imagine a space more holy than this?

Welcome to this sacred time and space.

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

Hymn of Gathering** ***O For a World **AZMON**
O for a world where everyone respects each other’s ways,
where love is lived and all is done with justice and with praise.

O for a world where goods are shared and misery relieved,
Where truth is spoken, children spared, equality achieved.

We welcome one world family and struggle with each choice
That opens us to unity and gives our vision voice.

The poor are rich, the weak are strong, the foolish ones are wise.
Tell all who mourn, outcasts belong, who perishes will rise.

O for a world preparing for God’s glorious reign of peace,
Where time and tears will be no more, and all but love will cease.

***Prayer of Awareness** **Rev. Fregin**
Holy God, you constantly remind us that
there is, under the mystery that is “us,”
a deep, abiding sense of oneness.
It calls us to see each other as works of art.
It calls us to hold each other as precious.
It manifests itself in each expression of love.

*As we worship this afternoon,
may we be filled with an awareness of that oneness,
and may it spill over our time of worship
to soak into, and through, the whole of our living.*

*As light into light we pray,
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit** **“We are the Ones”** **BERNICE JOHNSON REAGON,**
Laude arr. SAUNDER CHOI

***The Lord’s Prayer** **Charity Paniamogan**
*Eternal Spirit,
Earth-maker, Pain-bearer, Life-giver,
Source of all that is and that shall be.
Father and Mother of us all,
Loving God, in whom is heaven:*

*The hallowing of your name echo through the universe!
The way of your justice be followed
By all peoples of the world!
Your heavenly will be done
By all created beings!
Your commonwealth of peace and freedom
Sustain our hope and come on earth.*

*With the bread we need for today, feed us.
In the hurts we absorb from one another, forgive us.
In times of temptation and test, strengthen us.
From trials too great to endure and
From the grip of all that is evil, free us.*

*For you reign in the glory of power that is love and grace,
now and forever. Amen and Amen!* -New Zealand Book of Prayer

***Gloria Deo**
Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace** **Rev. Lehman**
Every time we gather in our sacred places,
we remind each other that the peace of God
is constantly with us.

Today, we ask God’s peace for each of us,
as we work to embody the Way of Jesus
and to transform the injustices of our world.
And we ask that the peace of God will change
hearts and minds...including ours.

This day, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition **Charity Paniamogan**

From the Gospel of Matthew, chapter 11

When Jesus finished teaching his twelve disciples, he went on from there to teach and preach in their cities.Now when John heard in prison about the things the Christ was doing, he sent word by his disciples to Jesus, asking, “Are you the one who is to come, or should we look for another?” Jesus responded, “Go, report to John what you hear and see.

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace...
Thanks be to God!

Sermon ***We are the Ones*** **Rev. Lehman**

Musical Reflection **“God, Make Me An Instrument”** **ROGER M. HOLLAND II**
Laude

Invitation to Silence, Prayer, and Giving **Rev. Fregin**



Prayers with the People

Invitation to Silence and Prayer
Hear these words from the Book of Amos in the Hebrew Bible:
Let justice roll down like waters,
and righteousness like an everflowing stream!

The God of compassion thirsts for justice;
and gives us all the vision of God’s way.
May this time of prayer help us to
share God’s scandalous grace with all in our midst,
hold those suffering injustice in our hearts and minds,
and inspire us to co-creating with God a more just world for all.

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts
Holy One, bless us with discomfort
at easy answers, half-truths, and superficial relationships
so that we may live from deep within our hearts.

*Bless us with anger
at injustice, oppression, and exploitation of your creation
so that we may work for justice, freedom, and peace.*

Bless us with tears
to shed for those who suffer pain, rejection, hunger, and war,
so that we may reach out our hands to comfort them and
to turn their pain into joy.

*And then, O God, bless us with just enough foolishness
to believe that we can make a difference in the world,
so that we can do what others claim cannot be done:
to bring justice and kindness to all our children and all our neighbors.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and amen.

Life this Weekend & Words of Blessing Rev. Ashley Hiestand & Rev. Lehman

Maybe in this time there has been a glimpse of the realm of God,
of what a community can be
that works for justice and equity.
Maybe it’s a foretaste,
a hint,
a promise.
Let it hold you and let it send you
so you will never be at peace...

Until all are fed
Until all know home
Until all are free
Until justice is done
Until peace is the way
Until grace is the law
Until love is the rule.

Until God’s realm comes
Until God’s realm comes
Until God’s realm comes
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

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First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Southern California Nevada Conference
UCC Annual Gathering
We are the Ones

29 May 2026



“The Miracle of Light While Flying”
Gerardo Dottori, 1931

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